

William Cobbett, Thomas Paine & Fleet Street

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William Cobbett (1763–1835) was a journalist, writer, and M.P. who started as a conservative but became a radical reformer, calling himself “the poor man’s friend.” He admired Thomas Paine and tried to bring Paine’s bones back to England, keeping them in Fleet Street until his death.

Meanwhile, young radicals like William Sherwin and Richard Carlile used Fleet Street shops to publish Paine’s banned works, including *The Age of Reason*, often facing imprisonment. Cobbett and Carlile both promoted Paine’s ideas - one through his writings and the other through publishing - helping keep radical ideas alive in Britain.

